

JAMES WILD & CO.

GALÁPAGOS

THE ISLANDS, READ IN ORDER OF AGE

A complimentary field guide to Galápagos cruises, land journeys and wildlife, island by island, from an explorer who first landed in 1991.

PREPARED FOR
Jane Traveler

START HERE
MEET IGGI

FIELD GUIDE NO. 01 · EDITION 2027
FOLIO JW-F-0001
COVER: SEA LION, SANTA FE · PHOTO: PIKAIA LODGE



HI, I'M IGGI · JAMES'S TRIP-BUILDING BUDDY

Every island in here has a page number. Circle the ones that make you grin, then find **Iggi's Compass** on the Galápagos page at jameswildco.com. Tell me your month and your crew; I'll sketch the voyage, James takes it from there. *Never lost. Only scenic.*

Dear Jane,

I first came here in 1991, and I still remember the feeling: I was Darwin. A small airport, a handful of boats in the whole archipelago, no guide at my elbow, and almost no one else going. You stepped off the panga and the islands simply carried on, sea lions asleep on the landing, boobies nesting on the path, a hawk close enough to touch, none of them the least bit bothered by us.

I've kept going back ever since, and the reason hasn't changed. The animals still don't care that we're there. The rock is still being made in the west and worn down in the east, so every island is a different chapter. And every time I go, I see something I walked straight past the time before.

Today far more people come, so how you go matters. Small ships, the right season, and a naturalist who has been doing this for decades. That's what this guide is for. Start with the rock, read the islands oldest to youngest, and the wildlife makes sense.

J. Wild CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER · FIRST LANDED 1991



	1991, WHEN I FIRST CAME	TODAY
VISITORS	Fewer than 50,000 a year (early 1990s)	About 330,000 a year (2023)
THE WAY IN	A small airport and a handful of boats	Daily flights, busy harbour towns and a long list of licensed ships
THE ANIMALS	Unafraid	Still unafraid. That's the miracle.

Contents

Read it in order, like the islands. Or start with the page that made you pick it up. Each part has its own colour, at the top of every page.

WELCOME · PLAN · EXPLORE · STAY & PREPARE · FOR THE CURIOUS · YOUR NOTES

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HOW TO READ THE MARKS

● I KNOW A PLACE	James has stayed or sailed there himself.
● I'VE WALKED IT	Inspected in person, every path and room.
● I KEEP GOING BACK	A founder favourite.
● I KNOW THE HOST	A personal introduction comes with the booking.
● I KNOW WHO KNOWS	Vetted through a partner we trust.
● I'LL KNOW SOON	On James's list, honestly marked.

THE COLOURS OF THIS GUIDE

Forest, sage, sand and linen: the house palette for every James Wild & Co. guide.

FOREST · SAGE · SAND · LINEN · INK

A conveyor belt you can stand on

Why visit the Galápagos: wildlife without fear, geology you can read island by island, and a national park that still says no.



◀ YOUNGER · WEST · WELL UNDER A MILLION YEARS

OLDER · EAST · ROUGHLY 3–4 MILLION YEARS ▶



The oldest residents keep the slowest schedule

PHOTO: PIKAIA LODGE

Wildlife without fear

Animals here evolved without hunters on land, and they still behave like it. You'll step around sea lions, not stalk them.

Geology you can read

Old islands in the east are worn and green; young ones in the west are black lava and still active. Sail one to the other and you watch the place being made.

A park that says no

The National Park sets every landing and time. Fewer people at each site, a naturalist with every group, and rules that keep it this way.

> *Give the islands enough days to tell the story in order. Five days is a trailer.*
>
> — J. WILD

Never trust a brochure with no weather in it

The best time to visit the Galápagos: December to May for warm water and calm seas, June to November for the cool garúa season and the liveliest wildlife.

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Season	warm	warm	warm	warm	warm	garúa	garúa	garúa	garúa	garúa	garúa	warm
Sea, approx.	24–26°	24–26°	24–26°	24–26°	24–26°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	24–26°
Albatross, Española	·	·	·	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●
Best for	snorkel	snorkel	snorkel	snorkel	snorkel	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	snorkel

DECEMBER – MAY

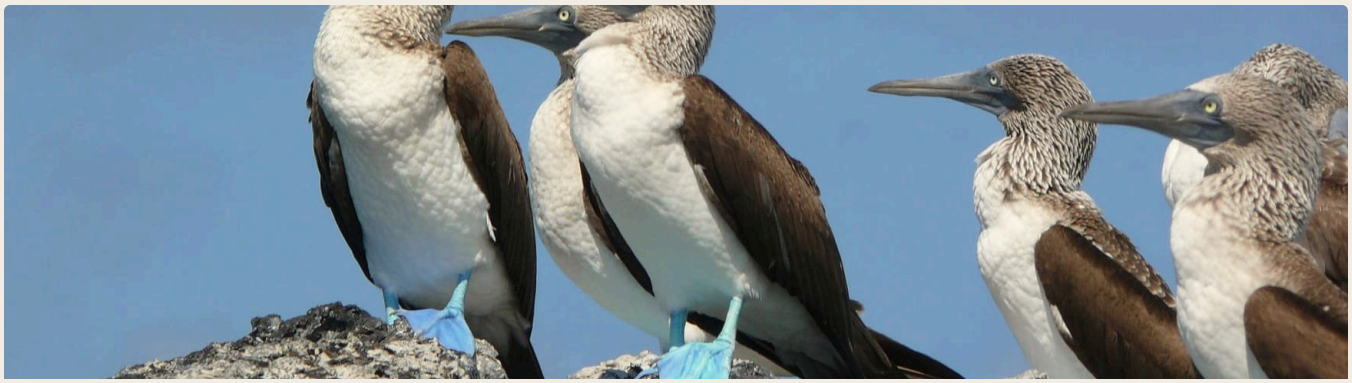
The warm season

Warmer water, calmer seas, green highlands and short showers. The snorkeler's choice.

JUNE – NOVEMBER

The garúa season

The Humboldt Current brings cool water, misty mornings and the richest marine life. Rougher crossings, livelier wildlife.



Blue-footed boobies: the dance is real, and it is not for you

PHOTO: PIKAIA LODGE

> *There's no bad month. There's only the month that suits you. Tell me whether you'd rather be warm or wowed, and I'll tell you when to go.*
>
> — J. WILD

Wildlife timing is approximate and varies by year; your naturalist confirms on the day.

Who the Galápagos is for, and who it isn't

The short answer: almost anyone curious, and nobody in a hurry. Here's how I'd match you.

BEST FOR	IDEAL LENGTH	BEST TIME	HOW
Curious people who like animals more than shopping	8 to 15 days; 5 is a trailer	Any month. Dec–May warm and calm, Jun–Nov cooler and wilder	Small ship, land lodge, or both

MADE FOR YOU IF YOU'RE…

First-timers
Come for the tortoises, leave rewriting your bucket list.

OUR PICK · THE CONTRAST · 9 DAYS, LAND THEN SEA

Families, kids about 8 and up
The only classroom where the homework naps on your towel.

OUR PICK · PIKAIA BY LAND, OR THE WHOLE YACHT

Couples & honeymooners
Romantic, though the blue-footed boobies will out-dance you.

OUR PICK · SEA STAR BALCONY SUITE, CRUISE A

Snorkelers & divers
Penguins on the equator. You'll stop trying to explain it.

OUR PICK · CRUISE C · THE YOUNG WEST

Photographers
For once the problem is the animals are too close.

OUR PICK · ESPAÑOLA & GENOVESA

Three generations
Grandparents on the sundeck, kids in the water, everyone at dinner.

OUR PICK · CHARTER THE WHOLE YACHT

Solo travelers
Sixteen guests. You'll leave with fifteen friends.

OUR PICK · SEA STAR · ASK ABOUT SINGLE RATES

THINK TWICE IF YOU'RE…

Bad sailors
The Pacific doesn't read itineraries.

OUR PICK · SLEEP ASHORE AT PIKAIA; DAY BOATS ONLY

Night owls
Lights out around nine. The stars are the after-party.

OUR PICK · ADD TWO NIGHTS IN QUITO

Beach loungers
The beaches are perfect, and already taken by sea lions.

OUR PICK · PAIR IT WITH ONE OF OUR BEACH STAYS

Anyone in a hurry
Five days is a trailer. You came for the film.

OUR PICK · STRETCH TO THE FULL CIRCLE

Limited mobility
Wet landings, lava underfoot, pangas that bob.

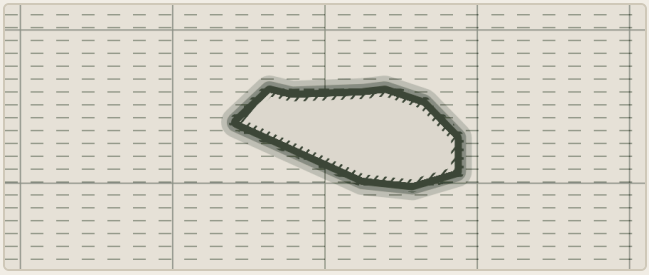
OUR PICK · PIKAIA AND THE GENTLER SITES

Minimum ages and landing rules vary by ship [confirm per program]. Not sure where you fit? Ask Iggi, or call me.

Six islands worth the crossing

Which Galápagos islands to visit, oldest to youngest, with the mark each one has earned.

THE LEDGER
I'VE WALKED IT
VETTED ON FOOT



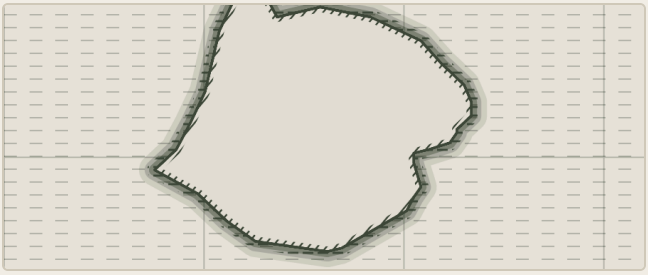
Española

● I'VE WALKED IT

The elder

Waved albatross (about Apr–Dec), the Suárez blowhole, sea lions on Gardner Bay.

DRY & WET LANDINGS · CRUISE A



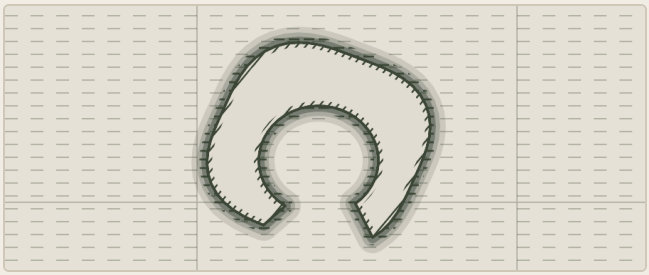
Floreana

● I'VE WALKED IT

Pirates and post

Flamingos at Cormorant Point, snorkelling Devil's Crown, the Post Office Bay barrel.

WET LANDINGS · CRUISE A



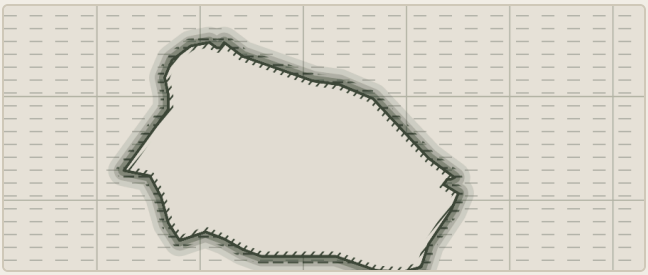
Genovesa

● I'VE WALKED IT

The bird island

Red-footed boobies, frigatebirds, storm petrels and, with luck, short-eared owls.

DRY & WET LANDINGS · CRUISE B



Santiago & Bartolomé

● I'VE WALKED IT

The lava fields

Pinnacle Rock from the summit, fresh pāhoehoe at Sullivan Bay, fur seals at Egas Port.

DRY & WET LANDINGS · CRUISES B & C



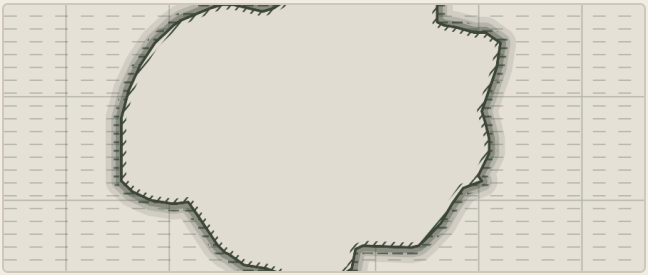
Isabela & Fernandina

● I'VE WALKED IT

The young west

Marine iguanas by the hundred, flightless cormorants, penguins on the equator.

DRY & WET LANDINGS · CRUISE C



Santa Cruz

● I'LL KNOW SOON

The highlands

Wild tortoises in the cloud forest, the breeding center, and Pikaia Lodge on the volcano.

ROAD & DAY BOAT · ALL JOURNEYS

Marks are samples for layout; James confirms each one before release.

Who you'll meet

Galápagos wildlife by island: penguins, cormorants, iguanas, hawks, fur seals and mantas, and where to look for each.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Galápagos penguin

ISABELA & FERNANDINA

The only penguin north of the equator. Snorkel the west to swim with one.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Flightless cormorant

FERNANDINA

Gave up flying because there was nowhere it needed to go.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Marine iguana

EVERYWHERE ON THE LAVA

The only lizard on earth that swims for its supper.

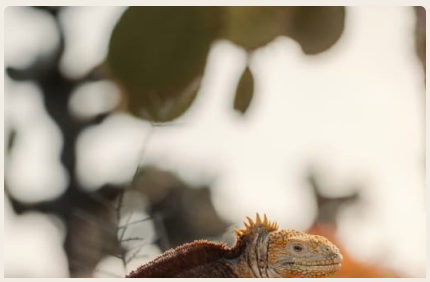


PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Land iguana

SOUTH PLAZA · ISABELA

Yellow, prehistoric and fond of cactus flowers.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Galápagos hawk

ESPAÑOLA · SANTIAGO

Close enough to touch. Don't.

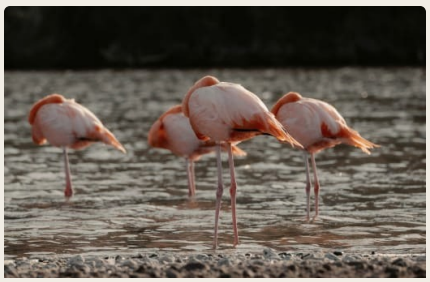


PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

American flamingo

FLOREANA · ISABELA

Pink against black lava, at Cormorant Point.

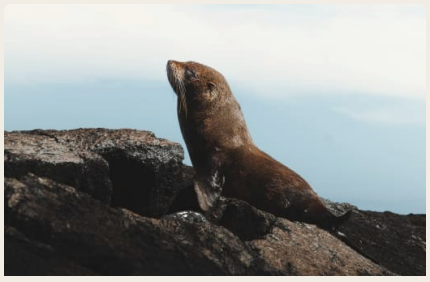


PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Fur seal

SANTIAGO · GENOVESA

Shyer than the sea lions, and the reason to snorkel Egas Port.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Darwin's finch

EVERY ISLAND

Small, brown and the most famous birds in science.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Manta ray

OPEN WATER, ISABELA

A shadow under the panga that turns out to be four metres wide.

Stay two metres from wildlife; it's the Park rule, and the animals didn't get the memo. Sightings are never guaranteed.

By sea, by land, or both

A small-ship cruise, a highlands lodge, or both in one trip: how the Galápagos options compare.

	BY SEA · SEA STAR	BY LAND · PIKAIA LODGE	BOTH · THE CONTRAST
Where you sleep	One suite that moves with you	One room on the Santa Cruz highlands, about 1,500 ft up	Three nights ashore, then the ship
Reach	The whole archipelago, incl. Genovesa & Fernandina	Islands near Santa Cruz by day yacht	Central islands, then the far west
Pace	Two landings a day	Day trips, then home to the lodge	Slow, then deep
Suits	Wildlife purists, solo travelers, charters	Families, poor sleepers at sea, hikers	First-timers with time
Nights · from	4–14 · $[____] pp	3 or more · $[____] pp	3 + 5 · $[____] pp



Your own deck for the passing islands PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS



The bed that doesn't move PHOTO: PIKAIA LODGE

THE LINGER-O-METER · THE SAME ARCHIPELAGO AT THREE SPEEDS

5
DAYS · CRUISE B
Genovesa's birds, Bartolomé's view, the highlands.
You miss: the old south, the young west.

9
DAYS · THE CONTRAST
Highlands and tortoises, then Isabela and Fernandina.
You miss: Española's albatross.

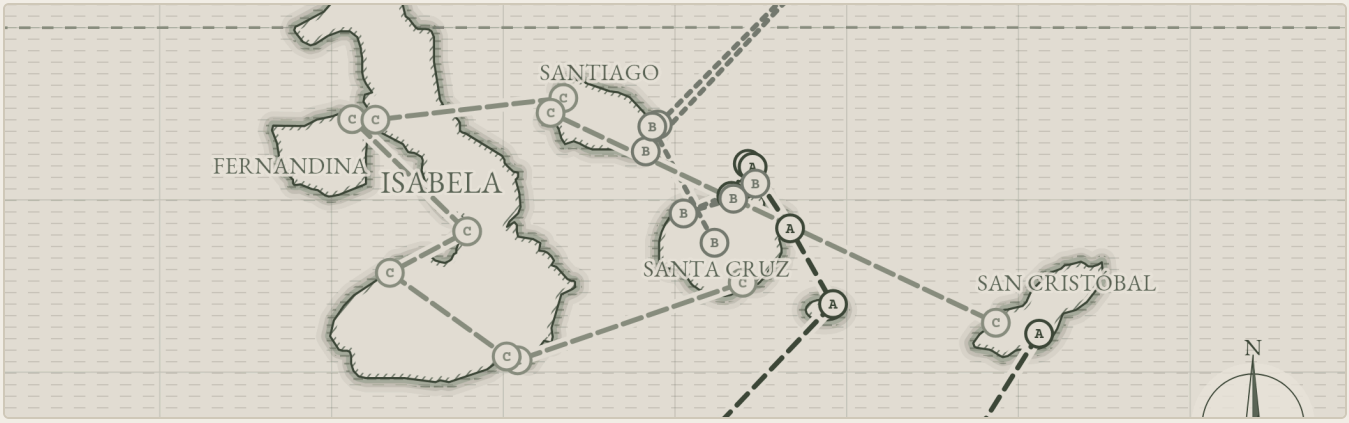
15
DAYS · THE FULL CIRCLE
Oldest to youngest, all three routes, one suite.
You miss: nothing but the office.

THE FULL CIRCLE
15 DAYS
ONE SUITE · OLDEST TO YOUNGEST

Oldest to Youngest

JW-VYG-004 · GALÁPAGOS SEA STAR · 16 GUESTS · 8 SUITES · WITH ROYAL GALAPAGOS

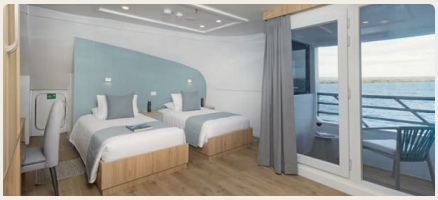
I KNOW WHO KNOWS



Cruise A — the old south · Cruise B ··· the north · Cruise C — the young west. The Park sets every landing.



The Sea Star at anchor ROYAL GALAPAGOS



Worth it for the 6 a.m. light ROYAL GALAPAGOS



Fire & frigatebirds PIKAIA LODGE

A	**Tue–Sun · The Old South.** San Cristóbal, Española, Floreana, Santa Fe, South Plaza, North Seymour.
B	**Sun–Thu · Fire & Frigatebirds.** Dragon Hill, Black Turtle Cove, Genovesa, Bartolomé, the highlands.
C	**Thu–Tue · The Young West.** Isabela, Sierra Negra, Elizabeth Bay, Fernandina, Santiago, Lobos.
A + B + C	**15 days · The Full Circle.** All three, back to back, one suite. Guests change at Baltra; you stay aboard.

WHO IT SUITS

Wildlife purists, solo travelers, families, and groups who take the whole yacht (8 suites, 16 guests).

FROM

$[____] pp · 4 nights

TIME REWARDED

Sail the Full Circle: [__]% off the third leg.

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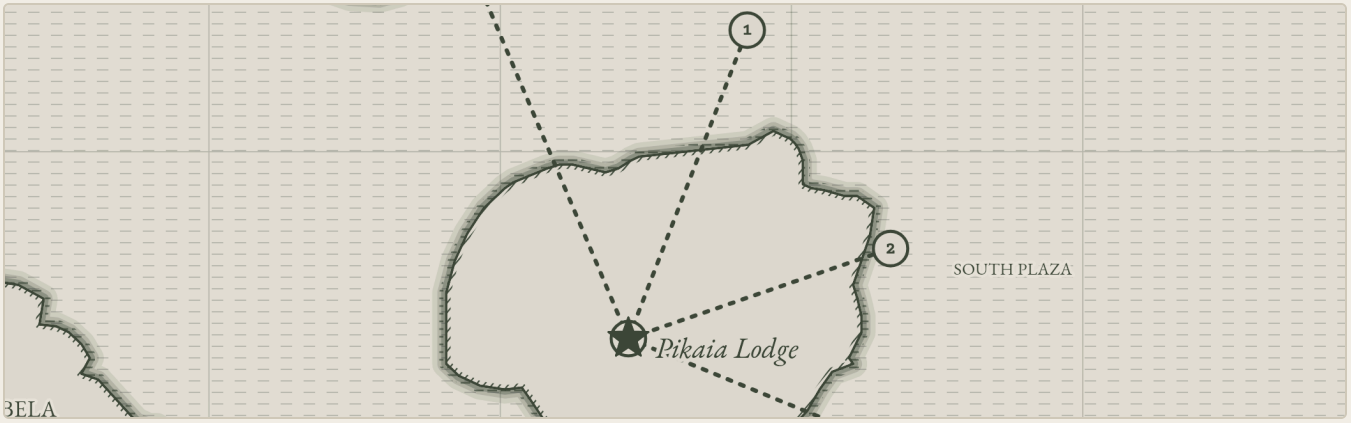
Like this one? Tap Iggi's Compass and start from this route.

> *If you can only do one, do the one with Fernandina in it.*
> — J. WILD

Highlands & Day Boats

SAMPLE LAND JOURNEY · PIKAIA LODGE, SANTA CRUZ · 14 ROOMS · ABOUT 1,500 FT UP

● I'LL KNOW SOON



Day trips by the lodge's own yacht · sample sites, set by the lodge and the Park.



On the rim of two craters — PIKAIA LODGE



One bed, islands by day boat — PIKAIA LODGE



The sea lion will find you — PIKAIA LODGE

DAY 1	**Up the volcano.** Land at Baltra, drive to the highlands. Tortoises on the lodge trails by evening.
DAY 2	**North Seymour by yacht.** Frigatebirds and blue-footed boobies at nesting distance.
DAY 3	**South Plaza & Santa Fe.** Land iguanas and a snorkel stop.
DAY 4	**Bartolomé.** The summit view over Pinnacle Rock.
DAY 5	**Garrapatero.** Bike to the beach, then fly home.

WHO IT SUITS

Families, travelers who sleep badly at sea, hikers, and anyone who wants one room for the whole stay.

FROM

$[____] pp · 4 nights

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night at Pikaia: [offer to confirm].

WAN-GAL-JW-F-0001

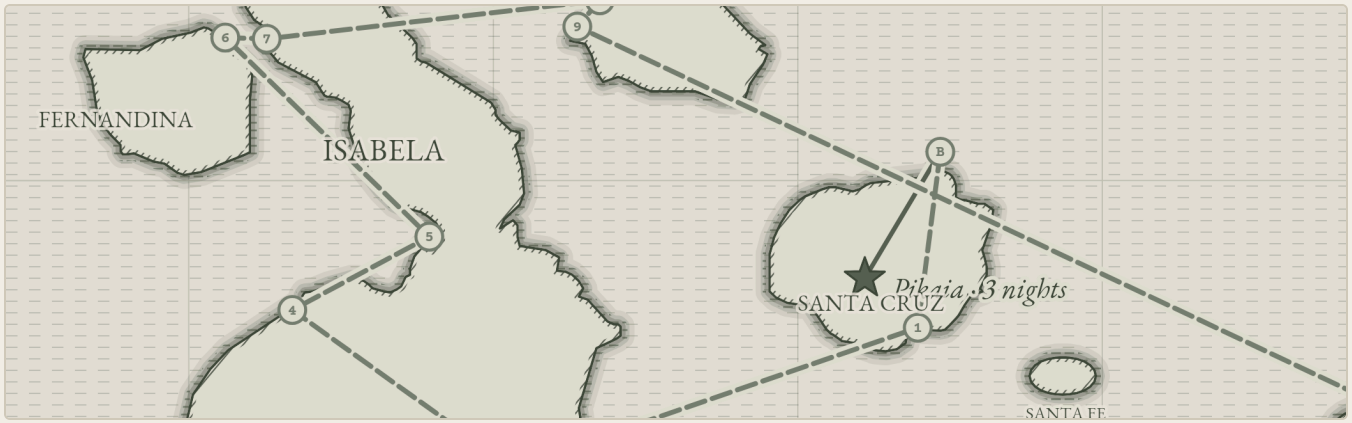
Like this one? Tap Iggi's Compass and start from this route.

> *Wake up to tortoises, fall asleep without a single wave. Some people call that cheating. I call it smart.*
> — J. WILD

The Contrast

JW-CON-G01 · 3 NIGHTS AT PIKAIA, THEN CRUISE C ABOARD THE SEA STAR · 9 DAYS

● I KEEP GOING BACK · THE JAMES WILD WAY



Pikaia Lodge, three nights · then Cruise C west to Isabela and Fernandina.



Earned at the pool — PIKAIA LODGE



Best seat for frigatebirds — ROYAL GALAPAGOS



Swims for its supper — PIKAIA LODGE

MON	**Arrive Baltra.** Up to Pikaia; tortoises before dinner.
TUE–WED	**Day boats from the highlands.** North Seymour, then Bartolomé or the Plazas.
THU	**Board the Sea Star.** Cruise C begins at Baltra; the breeding center that afternoon.
FRI–MON	**The young west.** Isabela, Fernandina, Santiago.
TUE	**Lobos Island, fly home.** From San Cristóbal.

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers with nine days, couples, and anyone nervous about a first night at sea.

FROM

$[____] pp · 8 nights

THE CONTRAST RATE

Land plus sea, priced together: [__].

CON-GAL-JW-F-0001



Like this one? Tap Iggi's Compass and start from this route.

> *Good journeys have seams. Land, then sea. You should feel the change.*
> — J. WILD

Every boat we'd put you on

Each can be chartered whole, 4 to 15 days, with naturalists, crew and every meal. Sixteen to twenty guests means every one of you is on the first panga.

THE FLEET APPROVED CHARTER THE WHOLE SHIP



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Galapagos Sea Star

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Our Oldest to Youngest yacht. Two jacuzzis, triple and connecting cabins.



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Galapagos Horizon

TRIMARAN · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

A balcony in every cabin. Three hulls for the channel crossings.



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Infinity

YACHT · LUXURY · 20 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Two bilingual naturalists and balconies throughout. Good for big families.



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Natural Paradise

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Upper-deck balcony suites plus a main-deck suite.



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Grand Majestic

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

A true master suite. The one for an anniversary charter.



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Galapagos Angel

YACHT · FIRST CLASS · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Two upper-deck suites and a friendlier price.



PHOTO: ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Calipso

YACHT · FIRST CLASS · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Cabins across three decks. Solid, unfussy, well run.



PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Origin · Theory · Evolve

EXPEDITION YACHTS · 20 GUESTS · ECOVENTURA

Three sister yachts. Pick by itinerary, not by name.



PHOTO: VIANATURA

Hermes

MEGA CATAMARAN · 2025 · 20 GUESTS · VIANATURA

164 feet, 20 crew, two butlers. The new benchmark for a whole-ship charter.

> *Take the whole boat and the itinerary becomes a conversation, not a brochure. Charter rates from $[____].*
>
> — J. WILD

Slower is the whole point

Why three nights on land is the house minimum, and the offers that reward staying longer.



Sombrero Chino, worth another night PHOTO: ECOVENTURA

Most Galápagos regrets are about time, not money. People fly a long way, see one route, and spend the flight home wondering about the other islands. We'd rather you stayed.

> *Three nights or don't bother. Night one you unpack. Night two you notice. Night three the place starts talking.*
> — J. WILD

TIME REWARDED

Sail the Full Circle

15 days, one suite, [__]% off the third leg.

TR-GAL-JW-F-0001

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night at Pikaia

[offer to confirm with the lodge]

WAN-GAL-JW-F-0001

ON THE HORIZON

Not this year? Next.

2028 departures with early-planner savings of [__].

OTH-GAL-JW-F-0001

Codes are tied to your Folio ID so your advisor sees which offer you chose.

The Galápagos entries

Every place, ship and lodge carries one mark. It tells you exactly how well we know it.



ENTRY	PLACE	MARK	MARGIN NOTE
L-101	Galápagos Sea Star · Royal Galapagos	I KNOW WHO KNOWS	*Sixteen guests. The naturalist decides, and is usually right.*
L-102	Pikaia Lodge · Santa Cruz highlands	I'LL KNOW SOON	*On the list for my next run west.*
L-103	Española · Suárez Point	I'VE WALKED IT	*Albatross from April. Bring patience and a hat.*
L-104	Genovesa · El Barranco	I'VE WALKED IT	*The bird island. Long lens, short sleeves.*
L-105	Fernandina · Espinoza Point	I'VE WALKED IT	*Younger than some of your relatives.*

Sample entries for layout. Every mark is confirmed by James before release.

RULES OF THE ROAD

STAY & PREPARE

01 **The smaller the boat, the bigger the sea.** First ashore, last back.

02 **Read a place in the order it was written.** Old islands first.

03 **Arrive the day before the day before.** Mainland flights run late; ships don't wait.

04 **Contrast beats coverage.** Land, then sea. You'll feel the change.

WORDS WE'VE STRUCK OUT

STAY & PREPARE

~~luxury cruise~~	It's a yacht with sixteen guests and a naturalist who knows every sea lion by its scars.
~~hidden gem~~	Nothing here is hidden. It's protected. Different thing.
~~once in a lifetime~~	Most of our guests come back. Plan for twice.

What to know, and what not to expect

Getting to the Galápagos, park fees, fitness, packing and straight answers.

Getting there

Fly to Guayaquil or Quito, then on to Baltra or San Cristóbal. Plan a night on the mainland first.

Fees at the door

Galápagos National Park entrance fee [US$200 adult, confirm] and Transit Control Card [US$20, confirm].

Fitness

Wet landings from pangas, uneven lava, short hikes in the sun. Tell us about knees and backs; we'll match the route.

Pack

Reef-safe sunscreen, a brimmed hat with a strap, water shoes, a light layer for garúa mornings, a dry bag, and a long lens if you have one.

What not to expect

~~Casino~~	The only gamble is whether the penguins show up.
~~Formal nights~~	Dress code: dry by dinner.
~~Your own landing times~~	The Park sets the clock. Everyone keeps it.
~~Hand-feeding~~	Two metres from wildlife. The animals didn't get the memo.
~~Strong Wi-Fi~~	Limited at sea. Post the photos at home.

Straight answers

Sea or land first time? Sea reaches more; land sleeps better. The Contrast does both.

Solo? Welcome on both. Ask about the single supplement.

Children? Strong fit. Age guidance [confirm per program].

Words you'll hear on board

Panga
The small inflatable boat that ferries you from ship to shore. Every landing starts with one.

Wet landing
You step off the panga into knee-deep water on a beach. Sandals, not socks.

Dry landing
You step from the panga onto rock or a jetty. Watch the swell, take the naturalist's hand.

Garúa
The cool, misty season (about June to November), when the Humboldt Current brings fog and rich seas.

Humboldt Current
Cold water flowing up from Antarctica. It feeds the penguins, fur seals and the best snorkelling.

Endemic
Found nowhere else on earth. In the Galápagos that covers most of the reptiles you will meet.

Hotspot
The plume of magma under the western islands that keeps building new land.

Pāhoehoe
Smooth, ropey lava, as on Santiago's Sullivan Bay. Beautiful, and hard on soft shoes.

Naturalist
Your Park-licensed guide. Every group ashore has one, by law.

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Your journey, in your hand

Fill it in, snap a photo and send it to James, or tap Iggi's Compass and answer the same questions online.

YOUR TRAVELER FOLIO
SEND IT BACK
JAMES READS EVERY MARK

When I'd like to go

Who's coming

Sea, land or both ☐ Sea Star ☐ Pikaia ☐ The Contrast

The island I circled

Something to celebrate

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A LAST WORD FROM JAMES

Jane, that's the Galápagos as I've come to know it since 1991. Circle what moves you, cross out what doesn't, and send it back to me. I'll read every mark and call you with a plan. The islands have waited a few million years. They can wait for you to get it right.

Til our next expedition, James

James Papagno · Chief Expedition Officer · james@jameswildco.com · 561.479.6355 · jameswildco.com/voyages?src=fg01

PHOTOGRAPHS Royal Galapagos (Galapagos Sea Star, Horizon, Infinity, Natural Paradise, Grand Majestic, Angel, Calipso); Pikaia Lodge Galápagos (cover, lodge, tortoise, sea lion, boobies, frigatebird, marine iguana); Ecoventura, photography by Brooke Pyke (wildlife, landscapes, Origin · Theory · Evolve); Vianatura (Hermes). Used with the permission of our partners.
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